

Solution Interview

Test whether a solution resonates with a user's problem

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

A Solution Interview presents a proposed solution to a user who has the target problem and probes whether it genuinely addresses their need, what they would pay or change, and where it falls short. It validates problem–solution fit before scaling.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Part of Steve Blank's customer-development method, elaborated by Cindy Alvarez (*Lean Customer Development*, 2014).

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

A solution can feel compelling to its makers yet miss the real problem. Structured interviews surface mismatch early, on evidence rather than enthusiasm.

HOW IT IS USED

Recruit users with the problem, show the solution or prototype, ask about fit, willingness to adopt and objections, and listen for signals of real demand.

WHEN IT IS USED

The Test phase, and throughout customer development.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Founders, product managers and researchers.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It focuses testing on **problem–solution fit**, complementing usability's focus on ease of use.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Usability Testing *Slibrary 9*

Minimum Viable Product (MVP) *Slibrary 8*

Feedback Capture Grid *Slibrary 9*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Blank, S. (2013) 'Why the Lean Start-Up Changes Everything', *Harvard Business Review*, 91(5), pp. 63–72.

Alvarez, C. (2014) *Lean Customer Development*. Sebastopol, CA: O'Reilly.

FIGURE 1 · INTERVIEW STRUCTURE



Figure 1. A structured solution interview moves from problem to solution and ends in an evidence-based fit decision.